PIA3142 Global Social Movements — Week 4: Saul Alinsky's Rules for Radicals

1. The Puzzle: What "Means"? (slide 2)

Keywords: structuralist critique, choice and chance, context vs outcomes, tactics

Recaps the critique of structuralism, then narrows the lecture to one question.

1.1 The Structuralist Critique — Structure Sets Context, Not Outcomes (slide 2)

Keywords: structural factors, context, leaders and followers, constraints

- Structural factors matter because they determine the *context* in which movements operate; they do **not** determine outcomes independently of what people choose to do.
- Outcomes are sensitive to both choice and chance: what determines outcomes is how leaders and followers respond to the challenges, incentives and constraints provided by structure.
- → Structure sets the odds, it does not fix the result.

1.2 Why the Question Becomes "Means" — From Structure to Tactics (slide 2)

Keywords: indeterminacy of outcomes, framing question, plan of the week

- If outcomes are not mechanically fixed by structure, the "means" or "tactics" movements choose become the decisive variable.
- The framing question, verbatim from the slide: **What "means"?**
- One-liner: structure supplies the constraints; means decide whether the opportunity is taken.
- Sequence of the week: Alinsky the man → his theory of society → ethics of means and ends → Gandhi → the organizer's mindset → tactics → anatomy of power → event-driven model.

2. Saul Alinsky (1909–72) — The Man and His Notoriety (slides 3–4)

Keywords: biography, assigned reading, conspiracy theories, ethics vs efficacy

2.1 Biography and the Assigned Reading — 1909–72, Left-Wing Organizer (slide 3)

Keywords: Jewish-American, workers and minorities, Rules for Radicals (1971)

- Saul Alinsky (1909–72) was a well-known Jewish-American left-wing activist who helped organize workers and minorities for a variety of causes.
- The assigned reading is Rules for Radicals, originally published in 1971. A single-author week: almost the whole lecture interrogates one doctrine.

2.2 Alinsky's Contemporary Reputation — The Obama Conspiracy Discourse (slide 4)

Keywords: right-wing conservatives, community organizer, secret socialist agenda

- American right-wing conservatives — most of whom, the lecturer stresses, have never read his work — treat Alinsky as a kind of evil figure.
- *Example:* when Barack Obama was president, conspiracy theories painted him as an Alinsky disciple using underhanded tactics for a secret radical agenda; the link was that Obama too had been a "community organizer" (slide 4 video: https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=dRae_JSWi-4).

2.3 The Two Reasons for His Notoriety — Ethics vs Efficacy (slide 4)

Keywords: controversial views, tactics that work, ethics vs effectiveness

- (1) Controversial views on means and ends; (2) his tactics actually work.
- The two are separable: the controversy concerns the **ethics**, the scholarly interest is the **efficacy**.

3. The Book's Opening: Dedication, Purpose, and the Three-Part Division of Society (slides 5–8)

Keywords: Lucifer, Machiavelli inverted, Haves, Have-Nots, Have-a-Little Want Mores, Do-Nothings

The ethics and the tactics only make sense once you accept Alinsky's picture of who is in society and what each part wants.

3.1 The Dedication to Lucifer — Provocation as Style (slide 5)

Keywords: deliberate provocation, authorial style, the first radical

- The book opens with a dedication to Lucifer — deliberate provocation: an "over-the-shoulder acknowledgment to the very first radical," who "rebelled against the establishment" and "at least won his own kingdom."

3.2 "The Purpose" — Machiavelli Inverted (slide 6)

Keywords: first chapter, The Prince, Haves vs Have-Nots, manual for taking power

- The first chapter is "The Purpose" — both the purpose of the book and the purpose of struggle.

- Its first sentence is the book's key quotation: "What follows is for those who want to change the world from what it is to what they believe it should be. The Prince was written by Machiavelli for the Haves on how to hold power. Rules for Radicals is written for the Have-Nots on how to take it away."
- The move inverts Machiavelli: *The Prince* is a manual for those already holding power; *Rules for Radicals* for those who do not.

3.3 The Three Parts of "Mankind" — Balance Sheet (memorise) (slides 6–7)

Keywords: Haves, Have-Nots, Have-a-Little Want Mores, political schizoids

- Alinsky divides "mankind" into "three parts"; his whole strategy depends on the classification.
- **the Haves** — enjoy "power, money, food, security, and luxury," are always the fewest, and want to keep things as they are; on their side are "justice, morality, law, and order [...] mere words when used by the Haves, which justify and secure their status quo."
- **the Have-Nots** — they have strength in numbers, that's all.
- **the Have-a-Little, Want Mores** — the middle class; Alinsky calls them political schizoids: "Torn between upholding the status quo to protect the little they have, yet wanting change so they can get more, they become split personalities."
- Analytical claim: the moral vocabulary of a society is not neutral — it is an instrument the Haves use to legitimate their position.

3.4 The Middle Class and the "Do-Nothings" — "I Agree with Your Ends but Not Your Means" (slide 8)

Keywords: middle-class majority, Do-Nothings, revolutionary leaders

- *Example:* in developed societies the Have-a-Little, Want Mores are the majority, and though most great revolutionary leaders have come from this group, most of it is Do-Nothings: "These Do-Nothings profess a commitment to social change for ideals of justice, equality, and opportunity, and then abstain from and discourage all effective action for change. They are known by their brand, 'I agree with your ends but not your means.'"
- → Bridge into means and ends: too much concern with the "morality" of means will lead to the triumph of "immoral" ends — the Do-Nothings' scrupulousness produces the bad outcome they claim to oppose.

4. "Of Means and Ends" — The Most Controversial Part of the Book (slides 9–16)

Keywords: particular ends/particular means, corrupt means, man of action, ten rules, moral garments

The ten rules build on each other and on the three-part division of society (Section 3).

4.1 The Core Argument — The Real Question (slides 9–10)

Keywords: meaningless question, corrupt means, man of action, allies of the Haves

- "Does the end justify the means" is "meaningless"; the real question is **"Does this particular end justify these particular means?"**
- "Corrupt means" do not "corrupt the ends," because "he who fears corruption fears life"; a real "man of action" should be willing to become "corrupt" and sacrifice his conscience for others.
- The man of action is Alinsky's ideal type: "views the issue of means and ends in pragmatic and strategic terms [...] He asks of ends only whether they are achievable and worth the cost; of means, only whether they will work."
- Consequence (from Section 3): those overly concerned with the "ethics" of means become allies of the Haves, who benefit from the Have-Nots' unwillingness to act — "morality" is for poor people, a way to keep them from pursuing their interest.

4.2 The Ten Rules, 1–4 — Interest, Who Judges, War, the Times (slides 11, 14)

Keywords: personal interest, political position, war, context of the times

All means are not good for all ends: how "immoral" one's means can be depends on the ends and the options available.

1. **Concern with the ethics of means and ends varies inversely with one's personal interest in the issue** — the more personally at stake, the greater the willingness to use "unethical" means.
2. **The judgment of the ethics of means depends on the political position of those sitting in judgment** — "ethical" often depends on *who does it*; all that matters is who wins and who loses.
3. **In war the end justifies almost any means.** Churchill, allied with Stalin's USSR: "I have only one purpose, the destruction of Hitler [...] If Hitler invaded Hell I would make at least a favorable reference to the Devil in the House of Commons."
4. **Judgment must be made in the context of the times in which the action occurred, not from any other chronological vantage point** — leaders should be willing to be inconsistent; consistency is not a virtue.

4.3 The Ten Rules, 5–10 — Exam-Friendly, Rule 10 Is the Key (slides 15–16)

Keywords: number of means available, importance of the end, success decides, imminent defeat/victory, moral garments, passport of morality

5. **Concern with ethics increases with the number of means available, and vice versa** — many options allow the most "moral" choice; few do not. Alinsky: "To me ethics is doing what is best for the most."
6. **The less important the end to be desired, the more one can afford to engage in ethical evaluations of means.**

7. **Generally, success or failure is a mighty determinant of ethics** — "if one succeeds he becomes a founding father."
8. **The morality of a means depends on whether it is employed at a time of imminent defeat or imminent victory.** *Example:* the atomic bombs on Hiroshima and Nagasaki (slide 16).
9. **Any effective means is automatically judged by the opposition as being unethical.**
10. **The key rule (memorise):** "You do what you can with what you have and clothe it with moral garments." This is the moral garments rule — justification is applied to action after the fact; great leaders (Churchill, Gandhi, Lincoln, Jefferson) "always invoked 'moral principles' to cover naked self-interest," and "All effective actions require the passport of morality." The passport of morality links back to Section 3: moral language is a currency everyone must hold.

4.4 Worked Example: The Declaration of Independence (1776) — Deceit by Omission (slides 12–13)

Keywords: call for war, 60/40 calculation, 100 per cent logic

- For Americans "a glorious document and an affirmation of human rights"; for the British "a statement notorious for its deceit by omission."
- It was a *call for war*: listing the benefits the colonists had received from Britain would have diluted the urgency "so [...] as to have been self-defeating."
- An honest document might have shown justice at 60 per cent on the colonists' side and 40 per cent on the British — and men do not leave wife, children, home and standing crops for a 20 per cent difference in "the balance of human justice."
- It therefore had to be "a 100 per cent statement of the justice of the cause of the colonists and a 100 per cent denunciation of the role of the British government as evil and unjust [...] in no war has the enemy or the cause ever been grey."
- *Example:* the Declaration applies rules 1, 2, 3 and 10 at once (slides 12–13).
- → The same 100-per-cent polarization logic returns in tactical rule 13 (Section 7.6).

5. The Gandhi Case — Demolishing Two Myths (slides 17–20)

Keywords: ahimsa, two myths, pragmatism not morality, conditional on the enemy

An extended application of rule 10 (moral garments): read it as that rule's illustration, not as a separate topic.

- Alinsky discusses Mohandas ("Mahatma," or "The Great") Gandhi, hero of Indian independence and icon of non-violence (ahimsa) — the moral standard to which polite international discourse holds most movements struggling against dictatorship and oppression.
- **Two myths demolished:** (1) his tactics were chosen because they were the most "moral" — they were chosen because they were most *effective*; (2) non-violence is a universal model applicable everywhere.

5.1 Myth One — Non-Violence Was Pragmatic, Not Moral (slides 18–19)

Keywords: no guns, no one to use them, compulsory disarmament, tactical repackaging

- The material point: Gandhi had no guns, while the British did; had he had guns, he would have had no one to use them.
- Gandhi's own writings assess the human capital available to him — a dispossessed, passive, demoralized mass — and condemn the British for "compulsory disarmament," which "has made us unmanly [...] has made us think we cannot look after ourselves."
- Alinsky: "These words more than suggest that if Gandhi had had the weapons for violent resistance and the people to use them this means would not have been so unreservedly rejected as the world would like to think."
- So non-violent passive resistance was chosen **exclusively on pragmatic grounds**, as the most effective means available.
- The lecture's oversimplified Gandhi: "Look, you are all sitting there anyway—so instead of sitting there, why don't you sit over here and while you're sitting, say Independence Now!"
- → Non-violence was not a moral conversion of the masses but a **tactical repackaging of what they were already doing**.

5.2 Myth Two — Non-Violence Requires a Liberal Enemy (slide 20)

Keywords: free press, Orwell, totalitarian counter-case

- Gandhi's methods only work in some contexts: his enemy was a British administration of "old, aristocratic, liberal tradition," which granted colonials a good deal of freedom — including a free press.
- *Example:* "Gandhi's passive resistance would never have had a chance against a totalitarian state such as that of the Nazis."
- George Orwell: "Without a free press and right of assembly it is impossible [...] to bring a mass movement into being, or even to make your intentions known to your adversary."
- → A tactic's effectiveness is *conditional on the structure and character of the opponent*: structure does not determine outcomes (Section 1), but it sets the constraints within which means are chosen.

6. The Organizer's Mindset — Compromise and Distance from Ideology (slides 21–22)

Keywords: compromise, true believer, two-part organizer, anti-ideology

Before tactics proper: the issues Alinsky thinks matter for radical organizers — and the striking point that he advocates "radical" tactics without being ideologically radical.

6.1 Compromise as the Organizer's Key Word — Demand 100, Settle for 30 (slide 21)

Keywords: free and open society, pragmatics of operation

- "to the organizer, compromise is a key and beautiful word [...] If you start with nothing, demand 100 per cent, then compromise for 30 per cent, you're 30 per cent ahead. [...] If I had to define a free and open society in one word, the word would be 'compromise'."

6.2 The True Believer and the Two-Part Organizer — Polarize in Public, Compromise in Private (slide 22)

Keywords: true believer, split self, no illusion

- Keep a distance from ideology "in order not to slip into becoming a true believer."
- "the organizer must be able to split himself into two parts—one part in the arena of action where he polarizes the issue to 100 to nothing [...] while the other part knows that when the time comes for negotiations that it really is only a 10 per cent difference."
- Distance from ideology also makes one "unlikely to disintegrate into cynicism and disillusionment, for he does not depend on illusion."
- → The two-part organizer explains why Alinsky's fanaticism and his pragmatism are not contradictions: the same person runs public polarization (Section 7.6) and private compromise (Section 6.1).

7. Alinsky's Rules for Tactics (slides 23–29)

Keywords: doing what you can with what you have, numbering gap, action vs justification

- Tactics are defined as "doing what you can with what you have." — the same formula as rule 10 of means and ends: tactics are the *action*; moral garments are the *justification*.
- **Numbering:** the list runs 1–10 then jumps to 13 (rules 11–12 not presented).

7.1 Tactical Rules 1–2 — Power, and the Experience of Your People (slide 23)

Keywords: disinformation, collapse of communication, prism of experience

11. **"Power is not only what you have but what the enemy thinks you have"** — can and should involve disinformation.
12. **"Never go outside the experience of your people"** — actions outside it produce "confusion, fear, and retreat," and a collapse of communication.

- Rule 2 generalizes to communication: people learn only through the prism of their experience, so the organizer must use language, symbols and tactics followers understand.

7.2 The Boston Massacre (1770) — Events Can Be Precipitated (slide 24)

Keywords: martyrs, manufactured incident, Samuel Adams, cold-bloodedness

- *Example:* the "Boston Massacre" (1770) — British soldiers killed 5 protesters; one of the sparks of the American Revolution (1776).

- Alinsky gives some credence to the theory that (a) the soldiers shot in self-defence but were effectively blamed by the colonists, and (b) the incident was planned by Samuel Adams for that purpose: "there ought to be no less than three or four killed so that we will have martyrs for the Revolution, but there must be no more than ten, because after you get beyond that number we no longer have martyrs but simply a sewage problem."
- Alinsky at his most cold-blooded: the deliberate manufacture of martyrs, with martyrdom having an *optimum*, not a maximum.
- → Events can be precipitated rather than waited for — developed in rule 13.

7.3 Tactical Rules 3–5 — The Enemy's Book of Rules, Ridicule (slide 25)

Keywords: enemy's experience, book of rules, the Haves' vulnerability

13. **"Wherever possible go outside of the experience of the enemy"** — cause "confusion, fear, and retreat." Symmetric with rule 2: inside your people's experience, outside the enemy's.
14. **"Make the enemy live up to their own book of rules"** — "they can no more obey their own rules than the Christian church can live up to Christianity." Since the Haves publicly pose as "the custodians of responsibility, morality, law, and justice," they can be constantly pushed to live up to their own book of morality.

- The tactical counterpart of Section 3: the Haves' reliance on moral vocabulary is also their vulnerability.

15. **"Ridicule is man's most potent weapon"** — almost impossible to counterattack, and it "infuriates the opposition, who then react to your advantage."

7.4 Tactical Rules 6–10 — Exam-Friendly, Sustaining Pressure (slides 26–27)

Keywords: enjoyment, drag, keep the pressure on, threat, action-reaction ad infinitum

16. **"A good tactic is one that your people enjoy"** — "if your people are not having a ball doing it, there is something very wrong with the tactic."
17. **"A tactic that drags on too long becomes a drag"** — militant interest can be sustained "for only a limited time, after which it becomes a ritualistic commitment, like going to church on Sunday mornings."
18. **"Keep the pressure on, with different tactics and actions, and utilize all events of the period for your purpose."**
19. **"The threat is usually more terrifying than the thing itself."**
20. **"The major premise for tactics is the development of operations that will maintain a constant pressure upon the opposition"** — "the action is in the reaction," and action is itself the consequence of reaction, "ad infinitum."

- Operational meaning, three directives: (a) use multiple tactics; (b) never use one tactic for too long; (c) be adaptable in reacting to events.

7.5 Rule 13 — Pick the Target, Freeze It, Personalize It (slide 28)

Keywords: complexity of blame, most vulnerable target, an actual person, not a system

- Rule 13: **"Pick the target, freeze it, personalize it, and polarize it."**
- Society is very complex, so blame will rarely be the fault of any one person — but activists must not get bogged down in these complexities.
- Pick a target — generally the *most vulnerable* — and focus all energy on it, ignoring others who might be to blame. The target must be an **actual person**: it is much harder to generate hostility towards inanimate structures or systems.

7.6 Rule 13 — Polarize: Us vs. Them (slide 29)

Keywords: 100% good vs 100% bad, the 60% bad problem, devil appeasers

- "Polarize" means the struggle must be defined in terms of "us vs. them," where us = 100% good and them = 100% bad; anyone not 100% with the movement is to be considered against it.
- One must ignore that the target is not really 100% bad: followers will not make great personal sacrifices to fight someone who is only, say, 60% bad.
- Enemies must be remade into devils, and anyone not 100% with the movement into "devil appeasers."
- → Same 100-per-cent logic as the Declaration (Section 4.4) — once applied to a document, once to a living target.

8. The Anatomy of Power Among the Haves (slides 30–31)

Keywords: fear of losing power, desire for more, internal competition, vulnerability, failure mode

Explains *why* pressure works: the Have-Nots must understand and exploit this structure.

8.1 The Argument — Competition Among the Haves Themselves (slide 30)

Keywords: Haves vs Haves, fear and desire, internecine struggle, seams

- The Haves are motivated by the fear of losing power and the desire for more power.
- This puts them in constant conflict with the Have-Nots, but also in constant competition with other Haves.
- → It is this *internal* competition that makes the Haves vulnerable.
- *Example:* "I [...] could persuade a millionaire on a Friday to subsidize a revolution for Saturday out of which he would make a huge profit on Sunday even though he was certain to be executed on Monday" — the Haves' self-interest is as shortsighted as anyone's.
- Strategic lesson: the Haves are not a unified bloc; the movement's job is to find and widen the seams.

8.2 The Failure Mode — Protest Leaders Who Missed It (slide 31)

Keywords: missed opportunities, instructive failures

- Alinsky also gives a series of examples of how *protest leaders have failed* to understand or exploit this competition for power among the Haves — the failure mode is as instructive as the success mode.

9. Alinsky's Model of Protest — Event-Driven Action and Reaction (slide 31)

Keywords: event-driven, action-reaction chain, creativity, five challenges

The general model the tactical rules serve, connecting the lecture back to Section 1.

- Protest as "event-driven": a chain of action and reaction between a social movement and its opposition that is very much open to choice, creativity, and innovation on both sides.
- The challenge for a movement (five moves): turn its own weaknesses into strengths; turn its opponents' strengths into weaknesses; precipitate events by frequently shifting tactics; goad opponents into mistakes and self-discredit; keep pressure on opponents and excitement high among supporters.
- The rules fit the model: rules 2, 3, 8, 9 and 10 keep the action-reaction chain moving; rule 13 gives it direction.
- → The rules stop looking like a miscellaneous list and become one theory.

10. Conclusions — Flexibility, Compromise, and the Loop Back to Structure (slide 32)

Keywords: flexibility, adaptability, aggressiveness + compromise, structural opportunities

10.1 The General Conclusion — The Two-Part Organizer Restated (slide 32)

Keywords: respond to events, no fixed plan, rhetoric vs pragmatism

- Be flexible and adaptable, so movements respond to events as they unfold instead of insisting on a plan fixed regardless of circumstances.
- Aggressiveness in rhetoric and tactics must be accompanied by a pragmatic attitude and openness to compromise — the two-part organizer of Section 6.2, now the general conclusion.

10.2 Creating Opportunities, Not Waiting for Them — Closing the Loop (slide 32)

Keywords: self-created openings, divide and destabilise

- This determines whether a movement takes advantage of structural opportunities.
- An effective movement does not wait for conditions to be just right; it creates its own opportunities by actions that divide and destabilize the opposition.

- → Closes the loop with Section 1: structure provides the opportunity, the choice of means decides whether it is taken — Alinsky's is a fully worked-out theory of the "means" side: controversial in ethics, effective in practice.
- Closing note (slide 32): two videos (both from 1971) are offered if time permits — keep in mind how old the material is.

11. One-Page Revision Spine

21. **Puzzle (S1):** structure sets context, not outcomes → **What "means"?**
22. **Alinsky (S2):** 1909–72 left-wing organizer; *Rules for Radicals* (1971); notorious for controversial means-and-ends views and tactics that work.
23. **Three-part society (S3):** Haves (fewest, own the moral vocabulary) / Have-Nots (numbers only) / Have-a-Little, Want Mores (political schizoids, mostly Do-Nothings: "I agree with your ends but not your means").
24. **Means and ends (S4.1):** "does the end justify the means" is meaningless → does *this* end justify *these* means?; the man of action; "morality" keeps the poor from their interest.
25. **Ten rules (S4.2–4.3):** interest; who judges; war (Churchill/Stalin/Hitler); the times; means available; importance of the end; success decides; imminent defeat/victory (Hiroshima); effective means judged unethical; **rule 10 — do what you can with what you have and clothe it with moral garments** → passport of morality.
26. **Declaration 1776 (S4.4):** "deceit by omission"; a call for war closes the 60/40 gap into 100 per cent justice.
27. **Gandhi (S5):** non-violence pragmatic not moral (no guns, no one to use them), and not universal (needs a liberal enemy with a free press — Orwell; hopeless against the Nazis).
28. **Organizer's mindset (S6):** compromise is "a key and beautiful word" (demand 100, settle for 30); avoid the true believer; two-part organizer — polarize 100-to-nothing in public, 10 per cent difference in private.
29. **Tactics (S7):** rules 1–10 then 13; power is what the enemy *thinks*; inside your people's experience, outside the enemy's; their own book of rules; ridicule; enjoyment; drag; pressure; threat; **rule 13 — pick, freeze, personalize, polarize**; dissenters become devil appeasers.
30. **Boston Massacre 1770 (S7.2):** Samuel Adams and the optimum number of martyrs — three or four, no more than ten, or "a sewage problem."
31. **Anatomy of power (S8):** Haves fear losing power, want more → compete with each other → that competition is their vulnerability; widen the seams.
32. **Event-driven protest (S9):** chain of action and reaction open to choice and creativity; turn weaknesses into strengths and vice versa; precipitate events; goad opponents; keep pressure up.
33. **Conclusion (S10):** flexibility over fixed plans; aggressiveness plus openness to compromise; structural opportunities are only taken if a movement creates its own openings.